Nutmeg and saffron bring out the delicate, nutty taste of the artichoke. Fresh is best, but canned and drained, or frozen and defrosted, artichoke hearts also work well.

globe artichoke soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE HALF-AND-HALF

1 tbsp olive oil
2 tbsp butter
½ Spanish onion, finely chopped
1 shallot, finely chopped
1 clove garlic, crushed
¼ tsp ground nutmeg
a few saffron strands
1¾lb (800g) artichoke hearts, chopped
salt and pepper
½ cup half-and-half
4 pieces of bacon or pancetta
a large handful of baby spinach leaves, chopped

1 Bring a full teapot to a boil. Put a sauté pan over medium heat and add the oil and butter. Add in the onion, shallot, garlic, nutmeg, and saffron, and stir for 3 minutes. Add the artichoke hearts and season lightly. Continue stirring and cooking for 3 minutes. Pour 1 quart (1 liter) of hot water from the teapot into the sauté pan and stir to mix. Bring to a simmer. Reduce the heat, cover, and simmer for 10 minutes, or until the vegetables are tender and cooked through. Let cool for several minutes.

2 Pour the soup into a blender and process until smooth, then pour back into the pan. Reheat gently, stirring occasionally. Meanwhile, heat the half-and-half until simmering in a small saucepan over medium heat.

3 Place a nonstick frying pan over medium-high heat. Once the pan is hot, add the bacon or pancetta. Sizzle for 2 minutes, until crisp and colored. Turn over with tongs and cook the other side until crisp. Drain on a plate lined with paper towels. Add the spinach to the same pan and stir until wilted. Turn off the heat.

4 Stir the simmering half-and-half into the soup. Taste and adjust the seasoning. Ladle the soup into bowls and add the spinach, stir lightly, then float the bacon or pancetta in the middle of each bowl. Serve at once.